Shanghai Virtual Lilong

Your guide to memorializing the historical way of Shanghai life

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Lilong, the traditional neighborhoods blending Western and Chinese architecture, are the embodiment of various cultural heritages that Shanghai has experienced since the 19th century. They hold memories of generations of Chinese families, migrant workers, and refugees, including famous political and artistic figures in Chinese history. Rapid urban modernization threatens to demolish and replace the Shanghai collective memory with commercialized malls and luxury apartments. Shanghai Virtual Lilong, is an interactive map where you can explore, discover, remember, and raise awareness of the untold stories of residents and the disappearance of Lilong in Shanghai through a select number of neighborhoods.

Lilong History

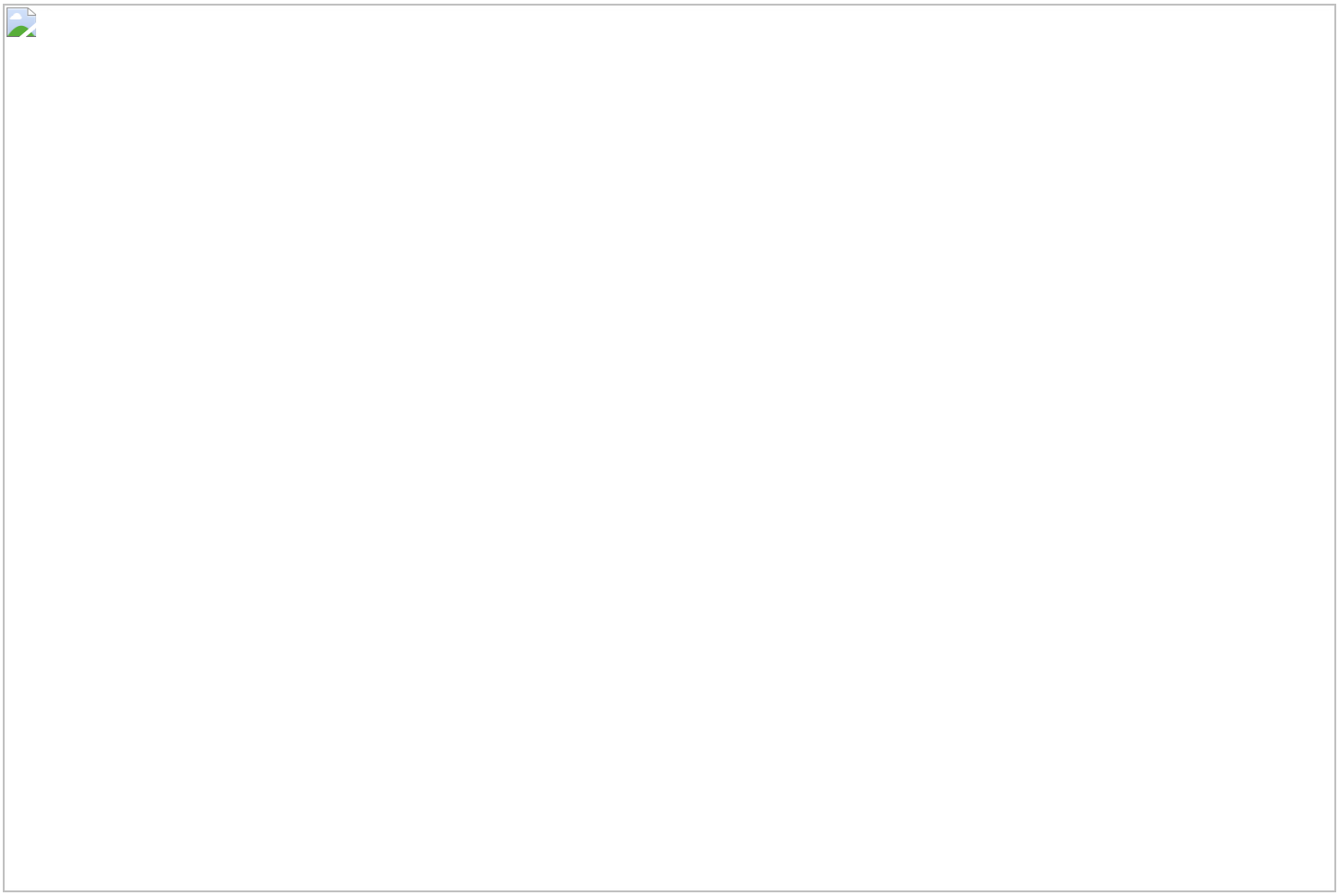


About the Lilong :

Lilong, or neighborhood alleyway, is a word that describes the lane-style neighborhood housing where about 90% of Shanghai's residents in the 20th century once lived. Lilong, a term that represents communal living in Chinese culture, is an architectural embodiment of international tradition. The Shikumen style is a combination of Britain's row houses and Beijing's Hutongs/ courtyard lanes. Each Lilong is distinguished by an arched stone gate (a Shikumen) —serving as a portal to forgotten eras of Shanghai.



Lilongs were originally constructed by British and Japanese companies residing in the former International Settlements from World War I. After World War II and the Communist Revolution, the international residents left the city, and migrant workers started families in Lilongs. Population and urbanization swelled, leaving tenants to divide and sublet what was formerly considered as single-family homes into tingzijian .



Yet, Lilong residents continued to form and thrive in communities. Neighbors met up for afternoon tea, mahjong clatter through the cobblestone, and children frolicking on bicycles. Stories like these, about generations of life in the Lilong, are in danger.



Today, the few Lilong left standing remain protected as Heritage sites in Shanghai. Younger residents move to high-rises and take their older family members with them. With that, the memory of the Lilong community continues to fade.

History of Shikumen Development

1843: The Treaty of Nanjing

Shanghai was open to foreign trade from 1843 to 1943. Starting 100 years of history within the International Settlement and French Concession.

1927: Greater Shanghai Plan for the “New China”

This plan reimagined a city with less focus on foreign occupation, to symbolize China’s efforts towards modernization. Thus, the creation of new urban centers and railroads by Chinese urban planners and architects were essential.

1949 The People's Republic of China

Becoming the most popular form of residence, the Shikumen made up about 70% of the city's built environment.

1993: The 365 Plan

Set by the Shanghai Municipal Government to demolish 365 hectares of debilitated housing or wēifáng( ), demolishing historical buildings and neighborhoods in its path.

Explore



Strolling through Shanghai's busy streets, you might catch **glimpses of stone arcades** revealing a quiet row of houses. The **noise grows louder** as Shanghai paves itself into a modern city. Demolition **threatens the peaceful facade and memories** of the Shikumen. Our map welcomes you to explore and share stories of different locations of **Shikumen in Shanghai**, helping us raise awareness on the preservation of these charming neighborhoods.

As of 2012, there remain 1900 Lilongs left in Shanghai (Zhang, 2014). Many have been demolished since then. This map is the record of 352 of their known addresses.



Shikumen sites

The figure to the left formats the collected addresses from our research and categorizes them into 5 different categories. Please note that the numbers and accuracy of these categories was limited to accessible online resources without proper on-site verification.

Shikumen Status

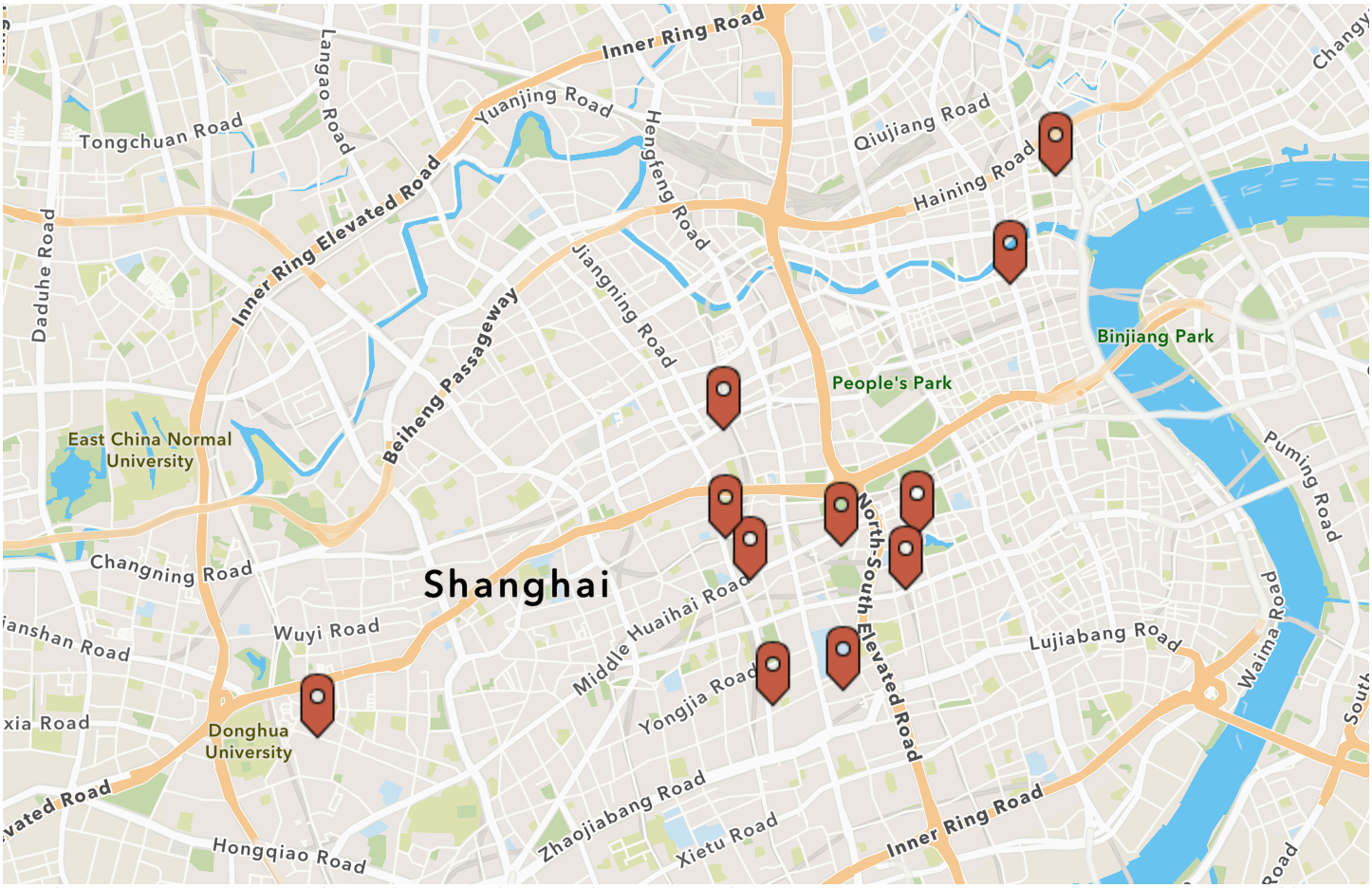
- Nationally Protected
- Shanghai Municipality Protected
- Shanghai Heritage Architecture
- Demolished since 2013
- Unprotected

One of the categories, Shanghai Heritage Architecture, does not necessarily grant building protection in a way that National and Municipality laws permit them. They can be demolished.

Learn

Here are neighborhood profiles of some of the Shikumen we have collected, including their histories and current state.

Note: those marked with a "*" are commercialized





Huaihai Fang *

Known as Xiafei Fang to its older Shanghai residents, Huaihai Fang or Joffre Terrace was named after General Joseph Joffre. Joffre was a French commander-in-chief during WWI. Built in 1924, this...



Shude Lane

Not far from Xintiandi, Shude Lane is steeped in China's "Red History." The Chinese Communist Party was founded in Shanghai's Shikumen, and Shude Li is home to the site of the First National...



Xinhua Lane

Founded in the early 20th century, Xinhua Lane was originally built to accommodate foreign immigrants and merchants, providing both residential and commercial spaces. As the city...



Xintiandi *

Xintiandi's design values the preservation and adaptive reuse of old buildings, improving the cultural taste and commercial value of the area. It also focuses on fostering the long-term development of...



Young Allen Court

In 1860, American Methodist missionary John Allen purchased land along Wusong Road south of Tanggu Road and established a school and church in the area. At that time, the buildings were...

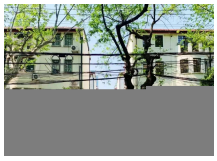
Cité Bourgogne

Cité Bourgogne was invested in 1930 by French companies and designed and built by China Jianye Real Estate Company. The name "Cité Bourgogne" (Burgundy) is inspired by the Burgundy region of...



Tianzifang *

Tianzifang is a successful example of resisting redevelopment. Artists, residents, and business owners were able to prevent the area's renovation, preserving its original 1930s architecture. It started as a...



Changle Terrace

Completed in 1929 by the Cathay Land Company, owned by British tycoon Victor Sassoon, Changle Terrace was originally built to cater to wealthy Chinese businessmen and politicians. Today its now...



Yuyang Lane

In August 1920, No. 6 Lao Yuyang Li became the birthplace of the Shanghai Socialist Youth League, a precursor to the Communist Party, marking a pivotal moment in Chinese communist history. That...



Jing'an Villa

Jing An Villa is a historic villa located in the Jing'an District of Shanghai, China. It was built in 1927 by the American architect Henry Murphy for the Chinese businessman and politician Silas Aaron...



Jixiang Lane

Jixiang Li, built in 1876, is one of Shanghai's oldest surviving shikumen lanes and is often considered a historical gem. Located just a stone's throw from the Bund, it was originally a residential area for...



Zhangyuan *

Zhang Yuan, known as the "Best Garden in Shanghai," was designed in 1882 by British architects and features unique shikumen houses that blend Chinese and Western architectural styles.



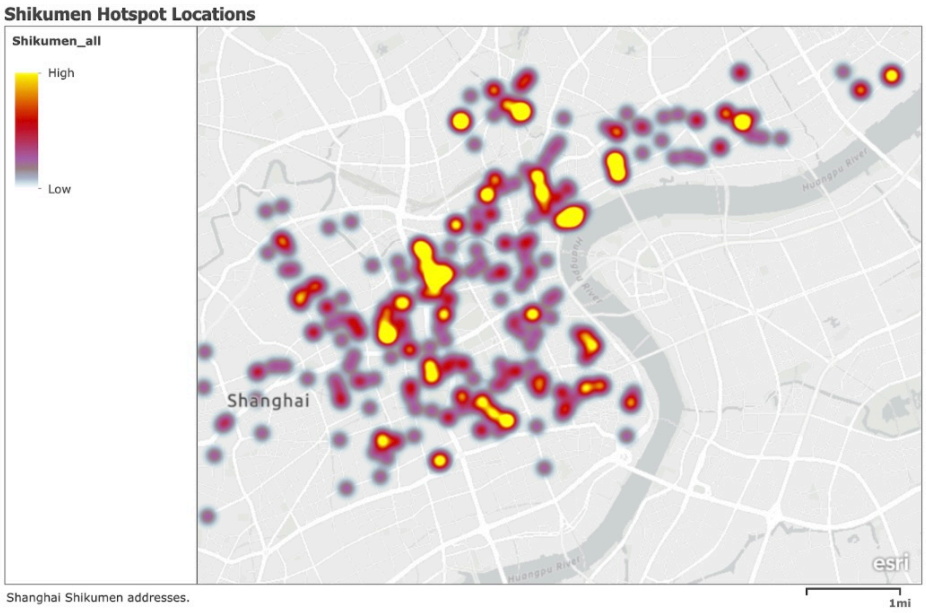
Lessons

The general landscape and real estate market of Shanghai have transformed fundamentally in the last 10 years. Whereas sales of commodity housing units decreased from 2,055.53 (10,000 sqm) in 2010 to 1,880.45 in 2021, real estate development investment has

doubled from 1,980.68 to 5,035.18 (in 100 million yuan) between the two time periods. This shift from mass residential development to redevelopment of aging housing signals future commercialization of heritage sites. The case of the Shikumen and Lilong communities is a classic illustration of the contradictions between urban renewal, commercialization, and cultural preservation.

The Commercialization of Cultural Heritage

Commercial tourism is one of the most promising sources of finance for Shanghai commodity housing development. Places with high traffic around central business districts, such as Xintiandi, show how traditional Shikumen can be redeveloped as lucrative commercial areas. These redeveloped neighborhoods attract high-end consumers and tourists, offering a sustainable financial model for preservation.



These hotspot regions reveals that many historically significant Shikumen are located near major tourist attractions, including People's Square and The Bund. These locations provide a strategic opportunity for developers to integrate cultural heritage with commercial viability, ensuring both economic sustainability and historical visibility.

The Fate of Shikumen: Between Preservation and Demolition

Although they are architecturally and culturally important, the future of the Shikumen in Shanghai is **to be determined**. Out of 500 identified Shikumen locations on this site, at least 21 have been found to be demolished, including protected sites like Fude Lane, Yuyang Lane, and Shude Lane, which are protected both nationally and municipally.

The experience of Shenyu Lane reveals how precarious is the fate of Shikumen. Historically one of the best-preserved Shikumen buildings after the Sino-Japanese War, was redeveloped in 2012. Although some of the original material were reused, displaced residents were made way for the construction of an eco-park and a mall. This is a common displacement pattern for business development that makes an appearance in plans for urban renewal, with moral effects of gentrification and cultural heritage loss.

Renovation and Gentrification: A Double-Edged Sword

Renovation can improve the quality of life for residents, but it often comes at the cost of gentrification. Some neighborhoods, such as 244 Wujin Road, have successfully incorporated communal living spaces and improved infrastructure while retaining residents. However, this is **the exception** rather than the norm.

In many cases, renovated Lilong neighborhoods transition from residential to commercial use, attracting wealthier and younger consumers. For example, Tongyili was transformed into a high-end shopping district, while Zhangyuan hosted a fashion show for its reopening, symbolizing its shift towards a luxury consumer base. The Jianyeli West Project similarly repurposed a Lilong neighborhood into a hotel, replacing local residents with a global clientele.

The Profitability of Historic Preservation

The redevelopment of Shanghai's Shikumen illustrates that historic preservation is largely determined by profitability. The integration of Chinese and European architectural influences makes these structures aesthetically appealing and commercially viable. However, the preservation of buildings does not necessarily equate to the preservation of communities.

About Us

Natalie Aramendia (left) and Chloe Alimurong (right) in Barcelona and Durham.

> *What can I do for you and what can you do for me?*
>
> Augustus Wendell, our first Boss.

Hello there! Thank you for checking out our project, Shanghai Virtual Lilong.

As the first two Urban Design graduates from Duke and Duke Kunshan, we felt called to make something out of the cities we lived in.

In Professor Andrew Field's class, *Shanghai: From Treaty Port to Metropolis*, Chloe read about and visited the famous Shikumen in Shanghai and had the idea to share its hidden history to the world. Natalie was excited to combine her interests in architecture, design, and GIS to make a digital narrative for the Shikumen. Shanghai gave us a

home, so we wanted to return a momento of history. This project wouldn't be without the tremendous help of student researchers: Baoguanyan Kang, Xinyu Zhou and Zihan Chen.

After Shanghai Virtual Lilong, Chloe will be pursuing her Masters in Urban Spatial Analytics at the University of Pennsylvania so she can make better and more maps. Natalie will be pursing her Masters in Urban Planning at Columbia University.

Special thank you to the support of Duke Kunshan University, Dr. Li Fang and the Innovation and Entrepreneurship Lab.

Credits and connect with us!

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https://www.yumpu.com/en/document/view/70269542/references References

Duke Kunshan University

Innovation and Entrepreneurship Lab (DII)